PAPERBOY

MONDAY, OCTOBER 19, 2026

France’s interior minister offered to resign over a weekend of rioting and looting, and Macron refused to let him.

AI

Anthropic commits 5% of itself to a benefit fund, and declines to say what that is worth

WHAT HAPPENED

On 18 October Anthropic announced that, “[s]ubject to stockholder approval, 5% of Anthropic’s shares will be committed today” to a public benefit fund — a wholly-owned LLC, chosen “rather than a 501(c)(3) or other format.” The board may add 2% more for every 50% rise in the company’s value above an undisclosed baseline. With the co-founders’ pledge of 80% of their equity and an employee match, Anthropic puts about 20% of shares in the public-good column. None of the LLC’s equity may fund “lobbying or political giving, in the US or abroad.” Governance, grant-making and the baseline are deferred to “the coming months.” The page’s only dollar figure is the $200m labour-market commitment.

WHAT IT MEANS

Five per cent of a company that has never published a share price is a promise denominated in its own markup, and the escalator makes the gift larger precisely when the company is worth more. The political-giving ban is the one falsifiable line here. Elon Musk replied within hours that Anthropic should give shares to the public instead — then did something like it himself (see Business).

WATCH NEXT

The stockholder vote, and the governance and baseline promised “in the coming months.”

Disney buys Character.AI’s plumbing for $20m and hires two-thirds of the staff

WHAT HAPPENED

Character Technologies filed for Chapter 11 on 12 October in the District of Delaware, case 26-11603 before Judge Brendan Shannon. Filings reported by PPC Land make Disney Worldwide Services the stalking-horse bidder at $20m plus transition services, for a non-exclusive perpetual licence to certain code and nine patents. The app, brand, domains, user chats, training data and finished models all stay in the estate. Separately Disney offered jobs to 66 of about 86 full-time staff — roughly $60m a year in compensation, about $180m over three years, plus a $30m retention pool. Break-up fee $700,000, minimum rival bid $21.7m; bids due 20 November, auction 23 November, sale hearing 24 November. A restructuring officer called the business a “melting ice cube.” TechCrunch reported the hiring on 18 October.

WHAT IT MEANS

A hiring with a receipt attached. Disney takes the engineers and the serving stack and leaves behind what made the company dangerous to own — the chat logs, the user data and the litigation they attracted. Expect the structure to be copied: where talent is the asset, Chapter 11 is cheaper than an acquisition and quieter than a lawsuit.

WATCH NEXT

Whether a rival bid clears $21.7m by 20 November; the auction on 23 November.

SEMICONDUCTORS

One Korean paper says Nvidia wants its custom HBM base dies built at TSMC

WHAT HAPPENED

Seoul Economic Daily reported on 18 October — relayed by TrendForce on the 19th — that Nvidia has asked Samsung, SK hynix and Micron to fabricate the base dies for NVHBM at TSMC on 3nm, instead of each memory maker using its own foundry. NVHBM is the custom memory Nvidia unveiled in August, whose base die absorbs the memory controller that normally sits on the GPU. Nothing in the report is confirmed by Nvidia, Samsung, SK hynix, Micron or TSMC, and the yield comparison circulating with it rests on unnamed industry estimates, so we are not printing it. Nvidia's own published claims for NVHBM are up to 30% more bandwidth per stack, 15% lower HBM power and up to 25% more compute die area than standard HBM4e.

WHAT IT MEANS

Moving the base die to one foundry would standardise the only part of a custom stack that would otherwise differ across three suppliers — worth real money in validation time. It would also be the first time Samsung and TSMC co-operated on manufacturing HBM rather than merely making their packaging interoperable, an awkward concession for Samsung's foundry arm. Treat it as a trade report, not a deal.

WATCH NEXT

SK hynix reports on 28 October and Samsung on 29 October; either could confirm or kill it.

Seoul rallied 1.76% and the chip stocks sat it out

WHAT HAPPENED

The KOSPI closed Monday at 5,768.01, up 1.76%, with the KOSDAQ at 808.89, up 1.78% — a second recovery session after the 15 October rout that took the index down 7.57% to 5,554.22, followed by a 2.05% bounce on the 16th (dated close table). Leadership rotated out of semiconductors entirely: Korea Times has Samsung SDI up 11.7%, POSCO Future M up 10.9% and LG Energy Solution up 7.2%, against Samsung Electronics up 1.16% and SK hynix up 0.39%. The won firmed to about 1,330 per dollar, a two-year high. The single-stock moves and the currency level are Korea Times' figures; no second dated source carried them.

WHAT IT MEANS

Two sessions of rebound the chipmakers barely joined is not a recovery in the AI trade; it is money moving to the part of the Korean market not priced off Nvidia's order book. Batteries leading semiconductors by ten points on a plus-1.76% day means the dip buyers are being selective rather than brave.

WATCH NEXT

Whether the chip names lead or lag the next up session; SK hynix on 28 October.

BUSINESS

China grew 4.5% in the third quarter and almost none of it came from Chinese consumers

WHAT HAPPENED

The National Bureau of Statistics reported on 19 October third-quarter GDP growth of 4.5% year on year, up from 4.3% in the second quarter, with the first three quarters at 4.6%. September industrial value added rose 5.5% (5.3% over nine months), while retail sales rose 1.1% in September and 1.1% across the nine months. Fixed-asset investment excluding rural households was down 7.2% year on year for January to September, at 33.4 trillion yuan; September alone was flat month on month, at plus 0.07%. The 4.5-5% target and the “beat” are media framings — NBS publishes no forecast. Stanford’s Zhiguo He told Al Jazeera “a managed slow slowdown is the best Beijing can hope for.”

WHAT IT MEANS

Investment down 7.2% over nine months is the property correction still working through, and 1.1% retail growth against 5.5% industrial output is the familiar answer: produce it and export it, because domestic demand will not absorb it. That is a trade-balance problem for everyone else long before it is a growth problem for China.

WATCH NEXT

Whether Beijing adds stimulus before the fourth quarter closes; the next monthly retail print.

Musk pledges one SpaceX share to every American child — about $10.5bn of stock

WHAT HAPPENED

In an X post shortly before 4am ET on Monday, Elon Musk wrote: “Next year, I will give one of my SpaceX shares to every kid in America. This will be the first of many.” Axios counts just over 72 million people under 18 in the US, per Census estimates as of July 2025. SpaceX has been listed on Nasdaq as SPCX since its 12 June 2026 IPO and closed Friday at $146.03, which puts the pledge at roughly $10.5bn — Axios’ own headline rounds that to “nearly $11 billion.” Musk did not define “kid,” set a date, explain eligibility or describe how shares would transfer, and SpaceX has said nothing. The post came hours after he urged Anthropic to give equity to the public instead of to a fund.

WHAT IT MEANS

One post, no mechanism, and a number large enough that the mechanism is the whole story — 72 million custodial accounts is an administrative undertaking, not a gesture. Read it for now as positioning against Anthropic’s structure rather than as a transfer anyone can diarise.

WATCH NEXT

Any SpaceX filing or statement describing a mechanism; whether “first of many” acquires a second instalment.

Bank of Korea expected to hold at 3% on Thursday, with November still live

WHAT HAPPENED

Korea Times reports the Bank of Korea is widely expected to hold at 3% on Thursday, having raised from 2.5% to 2.75% in July and to 3% in August. September CPI was 2.9% year on year, down from 3.1%, against a 2% target; core fell to 2.8% from 3.4%. Joo Won of the Hyundai Research Institute: “This time, the BOK is likely to pause and assess the effects of its previous rate increases.” Governor Shin Hyun-song told a parliamentary audit on 12 October that further rises “would depend on a close assessment of inflation.” Citi and Morgan Stanley both expect quarter-point moves in November and early 2027, reaching 3.5%.

WHAT IT MEANS

Korea is one of the few economies openly tightening into 2027 rather than arguing about when to stop, and it is doing so with a currency at a two-year high. If the won keeps firming the inflation case for November weakens, which is why Thursday’s dissent count matters more than the decision.

WATCH NEXT

Thursday’s decision and how many board members dissent for a hike.

STARTUPS

Thin, as a Monday morning usually is — finsmes and Crunchbase News had posted nothing past 16 October by 10:00 UTC. Two items worth your time.

Khosla leads $50m into India’s Even Healthcare at a $300m valuation

WHAT HAPPENED

Even Healthcare raised a $50m all-equity Series B at a $300m valuation — triple its mark 18 months ago — led by Khosla Ventures with Alpha Wave participating, taking total funding past $120m, TechCrunch reported on 19 October. It sells a subscription bundling primary care with hospitalisation cover, and claims about 250,000 members and more than 750,000 patient interactions since launching in 2021. The financials are early: FY2025 revenue of 272m rupees, about $2.86m, against a net loss of 902m rupees, about $9.5m — nearly a quarter wider year on year. Vinod Khosla said the “clinical and economic results so far give us conviction.”

WHAT IT MEANS

A $300m valuation on under $3m of revenue is a bet on the structure, not the numbers: that owning both the clinic and the risk pool fixes the incentive problem Indian health insurance has with hospitals. The loss widening faster than revenue is the thing to watch, because that structure only works at scale.

WATCH NEXT

Whether the loss narrows as membership grows; an FY2026 filing.

Bill Gross launches an idea factory and gives the ideas away

WHAT HAPPENED

Idealab founder Bill Gross launched Idealab.ai on 19 October, a platform he says has analysed more than 17 million sources to generate 1.2 million candidate business ideas, filterable by field, geography, market size, capital required and team size. He is giving the ideas away free and says he will help with financing, without naming amounts or terms — this is explicitly not a fund. Cloudflare is the first ecosystem partner, offering $100,000 in credits to companies started through the platform. Gross counts more than 175 companies launched by Idealab to date and says he wants to support 12,000. “I’ll put everything into this because this is more leverage.”

WHAT IT MEANS

The premise is that ideas were never the bottleneck, which is true, and that generating a million therefore changes something, which is less obvious. The interesting part is distribution: if the ideas are free and the credits real, the scarce input becomes founder time — and Gross gets first look at everyone who turns up.

WATCH NEXT

Whether any named company and round comes out of it; further ecosystem partners.

US

Obama attacks the citizenship investigation into Ilhan Omar

WHAT HAPPENED

Barack Obama posted a statement of more than 400 words on X on 18 October condemning the administration’s pursuit of Representative Ilhan Omar, saying it “should outrage all Americans, regardless of how they feel about Congresswoman Omar’s political views,” that “the full weight of the federal government is being brought down on a law-abiding elected official,” and that “if this becomes the new normal, there’s no reason to believe it will stop with her.” The investigation concerns paperwork from 26 years ago: Omar arrived from Somalia in 1995 and became a citizen through her father’s naturalisation in 2000, when records indicate she was 17. Investigators are reportedly seeking evidence she was a year older, which would have voided that citizenship. Omar calls the allegation “disgusting lies.” That the aim is denaturalisation and deportation is attributed by Axios to the Wall Street Journal and is unconfirmed; there is no DOJ comment and no charging document yet.

WHAT IT MEANS

Obama intervening by name, in public, two weeks before a midterm is a judgement that the ordinary channels are not working. The legal theory is narrow and old, which cuts both ways: hard to prove, and hard to end quickly.

WATCH NEXT

Any charging document or civil denaturalisation filing; whether Pirro’s separate financial-disclosure inquiry produces anything.

Vance says a town hall was the first he had heard of six soldiers killed in Kuwait

WHAT HAPPENED

At a CBS News town hall taped in West Palm Beach and aired over the weekend, Vice President JD Vance was asked about the six US soldiers killed by an Iranian drone strike in Kuwait — by Joey Amor, widow of Master Sergeant Nicole Amor, the first of them, killed on 1 March. “This literally is the first time I’ve heard of this,” Vance said, adding: “This job is an amazing honor, but you live in a bit of a bubble and sometimes information doesn’t filter up,” and conceding the troop positions were “a huge mistake that we could do better on.” Reported by the AP via PBS NewsHour; the page’s date furniture is inconsistent, so treat the air date as Saturday with low confidence.

WHAT IT MEANS

The admission is the story, and it is not really about Vance: six service members died in March in a theatre the administration calls a success, and the Vice President had not been told. That is a reporting-chain failure with a specific owner.

WATCH NEXT

Whether the Pentagon accounts for the Kuwait basing decision; any follow-up from the Amor family.

Maine’s Senate race turns on two words

WHAT HAPPENED

At the final Maine Senate debate in Bangor on 15 October, a protester objecting to data centres interrupted Senator Susan Collins, who said he was “obviously one of Troy’s supporters.” Her Democratic challenger Troy Jackson replied: “Oh, shut up. I don’t even know that kid.” On CNN on Sunday, Jackson declined to apologise, saying he would not be talked down to by Collins. Collins told Fox News on Friday the reply was revealing because it seemed automatic, and pointed to Jackson’s record on how he treats women who disagree with him. The Sunrise Movement said the protester was a member; the New York Times named him as Henry Elgie, 19, a Bowdoin student, who said he had “zero coordination” with the campaign.

WHAT IT MEANS

Collins has survived five cycles by being the Republican Maine will forgive, and the only way to beat that is to make the challenger the problem instead. Two words handed her the frame.

WATCH NEXT

The 3 November result; any public polling of the race in the final fortnight.

WORLD POLITICS

France’s interior minister offered to resign over the weekend riots; Macron said no

WHAT HAPPENED

Laurent Nunez offered his resignation on Monday after Saturday’s nationwide mobilisation turned to rioting and looting. “J’ai remis ma démission parce que je suis responsable de tout ce qui se passe,” he told France Inter, conceding a “manque d’anticipation” and a “perte de contrôle” (Entrevue). Macron refused, in an Élysée statement per Al Jazeera, to keep the chain of command intact, and asked for transparency on the planning and intelligence failures. The numbers have moved since the weekend: the Interior Ministry now counts 2,397 arrested on Saturday and 997 police and gendarmes injured, seven seriously. Justice Minister Gérald Darmanin put 2,331 in custody as of 8am Monday, 70% of them adults — “ce ne sont pas des lycéens” — asked prosecutors to seek pre-trial detention for looters, and conceded: “Nous avons failli, incontestablement” (Actu17). Another 350 were arrested in Paris on Sunday and overnight (Europe 1). Saturday’s turnout is disputed — 550,000 on the government’s count, 800,000 on the organisers’. Macron, in his televised address: “Nous ressentons tous ce soir de la colère, de la honte.”

WHAT IT MEANS

A minister resigning for a failure he has already called his own, and a President refusing it, is continuity chosen over accountability eight weeks before a budget that must pass by 17 December. The movement has no leadership, so there is nothing to concede and no one to concede it to. Tirana is the parallel — a sixth day of riots on Sunday, 272 injured since Tuesday, and a prime minister who also refuses to go.

WATCH NEXT

The “acte II” called for Saturday; whether the left-wing censure motion is filed; the 17 December Article 47 deadline.

Zelensky talks to Witkoff and Kushner for the first time since the rupture

WHAT HAPPENED

Zelensky held a roughly 40-minute call on Sunday with US envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner — the first contact with senior US officials since relations broke down about ten days earlier, Axios reported. They discussed US efforts to restart talks with Moscow, and Zelensky raised meeting in person “in the coming days.” Two disputes are live. Trump defended his sanctions waiver, writing that he does not “want to do anything that will drive, foolishly, Russia away from the bargaining table,” and accused Zelensky of striking Russian diesel refineries and of not wanting to end the war. Separately, on NBC’s Meet the Press, Zelensky said restrictions on the Starlink and Starshield systems Ukraine’s military uses “came from [the U.S.] government” and were executed by SpaceX, and that if Trump lifted them service “will immediately work as it was before.” Marco Rubio said on Saturday the US government was not involved and that service has been restored; Ukrainian officials dispute that. No Kremlin statement has surfaced, so Moscow’s position is unaddressed, not resolved.

WHAT IT MEANS

A channel reopening, not a thaw — it went through envoys rather than the President, which is how Washington signals a relationship being managed rather than repaired. The Starlink dispute matters more: if battlefield communications can be throttled and the throttling then denied, Ukraine has a capability it cannot plan around.

WATCH NEXT

Whether an in-person meeting is scheduled; any SpaceX or administration account of the Starlink restrictions.

Trump endorses Netanyahu nine days out, and threatens to do the job himself

WHAT HAPPENED

On Truth Social on Sunday, Trump gave Benjamin Netanyahu his “complete and total endorsement” ahead of Israel’s 27 October election, calling him “a Great Warrior Prime Minister, and an even greater Partner for Peace in combating the Islamic Republic of Iran.” He added: “If Israel has the wrong Leader, which would be anyone other than Bibi, America will have to do this work ourselves,” and, separately, “I am not inclined to do so” (Times of Israel). Asked by Axios the same day whether he could work with a different Israeli leader: “Maybe I will, maybe I won’t. Who wants to take the chance?” Reporting that he has privately called Netanyahu “his own worst enemy” rests on two unnamed people and is unconfirmed. Every recent poll leaves both blocs short of the 61 seats needed, and the order flips between them: a 15 October Times of Israel/Tatika poll had the pro-Netanyahu bloc on 49 against 54, a Channel 13/Madad poll the day before had 51 against 50 (poll detail).

WHAT IT MEANS

A sitting US president conditioning American military action on another country’s election result, in public, nine days before the vote. Whether it moves Israeli voters is unclear — it has cut both ways before — but it removes any ambiguity about what Washington wants, which makes the result harder for either side to spin afterwards.

WATCH NEXT

The 27 October result and the coalition arithmetic; whether the deferred Iran operation surfaces after the US midterms.

SOURCES

Anthropic — Our Public Benefit Fund

TechCrunch — Anthropic commits 5% of its shares

TechCrunch — Disney to hire most of Character.AI’s workforce

PPC Land — Disney pays $20m for Character.AI’s IP

TrendForce — Nvidia reportedly pushes TSMC 3nm NVHBM base dies

NVIDIA Developer — NVLink Fusion brings NVHBM to next-generation AI infrastructure

Korea Times — KOSPI edges higher as battery, auto gains power market

Investing.com — KOSPI historical data

National Bureau of Statistics of China — Q3 2026 national economy

Al Jazeera — China’s economy grows 4.5% in Q3

Axios — Musk pledges a SpaceX share to every American child

StockAnalysis — SpaceX (Nasdaq: SPCX)

Korea Times — BOK poised to hold rates

TechCrunch — Khosla Ventures doubles down on Even Healthcare

Axios — Bill Gross launches Idealab.ai

Axios — Obama on the Ilhan Omar citizenship investigation

PBS NewsHour / AP — Vance faces tough questions in CBS town hall

PBS NewsHour / AP — Jackson doesn’t regret telling Collins to shut up

Al Jazeera — Macron declines minister’s resignation

Entrevue — Nunez: “je suis responsable de tout ce qui se passe”

Actu17 — Darmanin announces pre-trial detentions

Europe 1 — 350 interpellations in Paris on Sunday

Al Jazeera — Sixth day of protests in Tirana

Axios — Zelensky speaks to Witkoff and Kushner

Times of Israel — Trump offers Netanyahu complete and total endorsement

Times of Israel — TOI poll: both blocs short of a majority

Al Jazeera — GCC condemns Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia